> respected for its enduring culture, but equally, there is a growing admiration for the achievement of building a credible democracy under very challenging conditions.[29]

Beyond strict culture, Jaishankar's remarks allude to a variety of other soft power components, including political, economic, and technological factors that shape India's developmental model. Reflecting this approach, a submission by the Ministry of External Affairs to the same parliamentary committee would further emphasise this pluralist view:

> "Culture" is a dynamic concept characterizing the Indian society and manifested in our collectively held attributes, which include teaching and learning (socialization, language, literature), ideas (identity, Philosophy and way of thinking), value system (democratic and secular), norms (economic systems, traditions, varied art forms and sports) and India's institutional structures (family, Constitution and political systems).[30]

Finally, linking this pluralist definition of Indian power to the regional context of a rising China and India's need to reassure the immediate neighbourhood, Jaishankar also underlined the utility of soft power to the country's larger foreign policy priorities:

> The very lack of assertiveness, the diffusion of the personality, somehow the pluralism of India which sometimes looks much more fuzzy because it does not have the sharp edges, it actually makes people more comfortable, at least, less threatened. A part of it was also because a democratic country with a culture of